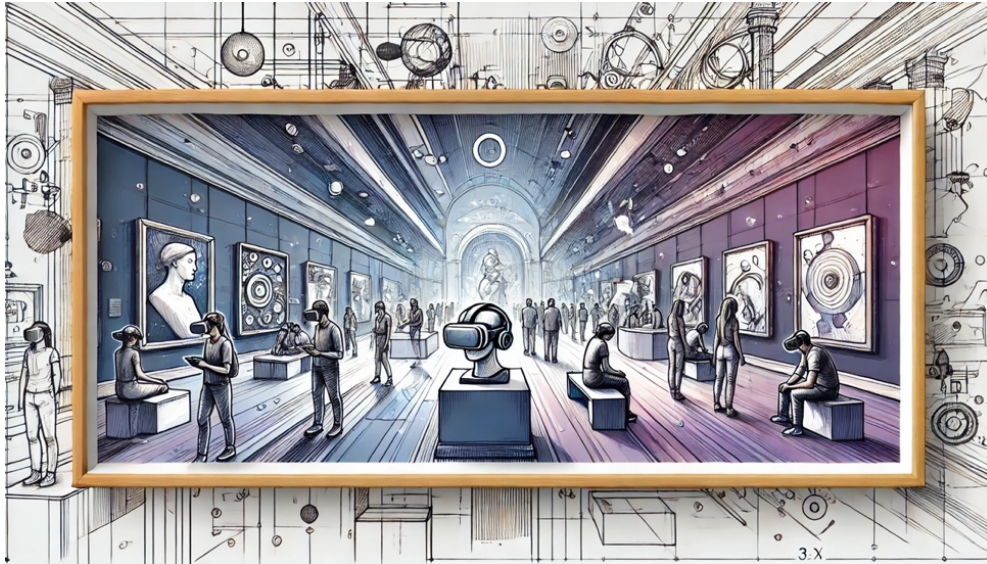


ANTH 2800 Museum Anthropology

Fall 2026 | Th 1:35-4:55pm | Forsyth 236



Prof. Nina Sylvanus
Drop-in Hours: Wednesday 10:00-12:00 am

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Course Description

Museums are among the most influential institutions through which societies preserve the past, produce knowledge, and imagine collective futures. Yet museums do far more than collect and display objects: they organize historical narratives, establish cultural authority, shape public memory, and mediate relationships between communities, knowledge, and material heritage.

Drawing on museum anthropology and critical museum studies, this course examines museums as sites where history, science, art, and politics are actively produced and negotiated. We explore how collections are assembled, how exhibitions construct narratives and experiences, how provenance research reshapes curatorial practice, and how museums confront the colonial legacies embedded in their collections through restitution, ethical stewardship, and collaborative forms of care. By comparing anthropology museums, art museums, and science museums, students examine how different museum genres communicate expertise, engage visitors, and negotiate their responsibilities to diverse publics.

The course is organized around a progression from **understanding museums** to **making museums**. We begin by asking fundamental questions about the origins and purposes of museums, before examining how exhibitions produce particular understandings of time, culture, and history. We then turn to the ethical and political challenges facing museums today—including provenance research, colonial modernity, restitution, and repair—before shifting to the practical work of exhibition development, visitor engagement, and curatorial decision-making. Throughout the semester, students are encouraged to think not only as critics of museums but also as curators, exhibition designers, and public scholars.

Designed as an experiential seminar, the course combines discussion-based seminars with object-based learning, gallery analysis, collaborative workshops, and field visits to major museums in the Boston area. Visits to the Museum of Fine Arts, the Harvard Peabody Museum, the MIT Museum, and the Harvard Art Museums provide opportunities to engage directly with curators, provenance researchers, exhibition developers, and museum educators, connecting theoretical debates to contemporary museum practice.

The semester is anchored by a **Curatorial Lab**, in which students work in small groups to develop an original exhibition proposal. Drawing on the concepts, methods, and museum practices encountered throughout the course, each group develops a curatorial argument, selects and interprets a small group of objects, designs an exhibition narrative and visitor experience, and reflects on the ethical, historical, and interpretive choices involved in exhibition-making. Through iterative workshops, consultations with museum professionals, and peer critiques, students develop their projects over the course of the semester, culminating in a final exhibition proposal and public presentation.

Part I: Understanding Museums (Weeks 1–5)

How do museums make knowledge, history, and value?

Students learn to analyze museums as institutions:

- Why museums?
- Time and narrative
- Provenance
- Colonial modernity
- Ethical stewardship
- Repair and restitution

	Date	Topic	Content	Key readings
1	Sept 10	The Museum Question	If museums didn't exist, would we invent them? An anthropological introduction to the history, purposes and politics of museums as institutions of knowledge, memory, and power. Concludes with a group visit to MFA exhibition <i>Maverick Kings: Three Visionary Pharaohs of Egypt's Golden Age</i>; short timeline-sketching exercise.	Arjun Appadurai (2020) " Museums and the Savage Sublime ," in <i>Across Anthropology</i> .

2	Sept 17	Making Museum Objects & Provenance Research as Method	How do museums construct historical narratives, and how do provenance researchers reconstruct the histories of individual objects? From exhibition storytelling to the biographies of things. Class meets with MFA provenance curator Victoria Reed (3:30-4:50)	Njabulo Chipangura, Yunci Cai & Sophie Delepiere (2025) "Provenance Research in Museums: Principles, Practices and Possibilities." <i>Museum International</i> , 77:3-4, iv-ix. Anne Nielsen (2025) Making the Unaccountable Accountable., <i>Museum International</i> 77:3-4, 118-129
3	Sept 24	Museums, Colonial Modernity, and Coevalness	How have museums produced colonial ways of seeing? Drawing on coevalness and the museum as a history of relations, we ask what it would mean to imagine a different museum.	Wayne Modest & Peter Peels (2024) <i>The Time of and for the Museum</i> (core theoretical text) Miriam Ticktin, <i>The Museum as a Space of Radical Imagination</i>
4	Oct 1	Ethical stewardship & Care	How are museums responding to colonial collections today? Through a visit to the Harvard Peabody Museum , we examine ethical stewardship, NAGPRA, collaboration with descendant communities, and the changing responsibilities of anthropology museums as spaces of care.	LISTEN: "Curating the Peabody Museum's North American Collections with Curator Stephanie Mach" HMSC Connects Podcast (November 15, 2023, 43 minutes) READ: Wayne Modest (2023) <i>Spaces of Care: Confronting Colonial Afterlives in European Ethnographic Museums</i> . SKIM READ: Adam Kuper (2025) on History of Harvard's Peabody Museum
5	Oct 8	Repair	What forms of repair are possible after colonial dispossession? Through debates on restitution, the Benin Bronzes, Mati Diop's <i>Dahomey</i> , and contemporary artistic and digital interventions, we examine competing visions of justice, return, and historical responsibility.	Media: Dahomey (watch before class) Digital Heist Looted (trailer/gameplay) READ: *Ciraj Rassool & V.E. Gibbon, V. E. (2023). Restitution versus repatriation: Terminology and concepts matter . <i>American Journal of Biological Anthropology</i> , 1–4. Dilger, 2026 Ngonnso, <i>American Ethnologist</i> Bénédicte Savoy Selected chapter from <i>Africa's Struggle for Its Art</i>

Part II: Making Museums (Weeks 6–12)

How do museums become exhibitions?

Students encounter and experience museum practice:

- Exhibition design (MIT)
- Digital prototyping
- Study Center / object selection (Harvard Art Museum)
- Curatorial thinking
- Studio critiques
- Final exhibition proposals

6	Oct 15	Exhibition Design	How is knowledge transformed into a museum experience? Through a visit to the MIT Museum , students explore exhibition development, visitor participation, and interpretive design while gaining practical insights for their own curatorial lab projects.	TBD
7	Oct 22	Prototyping Exhibitions	Hands-on workshop introducing digital tools and approaches to exhibition development. In collaboration with the Digital Integration Teaching Initiative, students experiment with technologies, develop initial concepts, and prototype ideas for their semester-long exhibition projects.	TBD
8	Oct 29	Curating Objects	How do objects become exhibitions? Through a workshop at the Harvard Art Museums Study Center , students examine curatorial decision-making, object interpretation, and collection-based research while developing ideas for their own exhibition projects.	Arjun Appadurai (1986) <i>The Social Life of Things</i> .
9	Nov 12	Curatorial Practice	Studio workshop devoted to the development of students' exhibition projects. Through peer critique and a virtual conversation with curator Priya Swamy (Wereldmuseum Amsterdam), students examine how curatorial concepts evolve into exhibitions and refine their own proposals.	TBD
10	Nov 19	Curatorial Critique	Students present their developing exhibition concepts for structured peer review. The workshop focuses on refining the conceptual argument, object selection, narrative, visitor experience, and exhibition design before final presentations. This is not a presentation of finished work. Each student (or group?) presents for about 8 minutes: exhibition title, central question, audience, 4–6 key objects, exhibition layout, biggest conceptual challenge. Followed with 10 minutes of critique.	
11	Nov 26	— Thanksgiving (no class)	—	—

12	Dec 3	Lab Exhibit Presentation I	Final exhibition presentations followed by critiques from invited faculty and museum professionals.	
13	Dec 10	Lab Exhibit Presentation II	Final exhibition presentations and concluding reflections on museums, curation, and the public life of anthropology.	